

David Hall

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Education

University of Oregon — Ph.D. in Economics Fall 2022–Summer 2027 (expected)
Fields: *Health, Public, Applied Econometrics*

California Lutheran University — M.S. in Quantitative Economics May 2022
Thesis: *Forecast of Employment Inflows and Outflows*.

California Lutheran University — B.A. in Economics and Mathematics May 2021
Theses: *The Effect of Different-Race Policing on Excessive Use-of-Force Cases* (Economics) and *An Optimization of Political Lying* (Mathematics).

Academic Appointments

Research Assistant, University of Oregon Summer 2025–Present
Benjamin Hansen (PI); funded by Arnold Ventures.

Lead Instructor, Introduction to Econometrics (EC320) Fall 2025
University of Oregon

Predoctoral Fellow, Behavioral Science Training: Drug Abuse (NIH T32) Summer 2023–Summer 2025
New York University.

Teaching Assistant; EC101, EC201, EC202 Fall 2022–Spring 2023
University of Oregon

Overton Fellow in Economics, California Lutheran University Summer 2020
Project: *The Effect of Police Agency Unionization on Use-of-Force Cases*.

Job Market Paper

Pour Decisions: Alcohol Privatization and Birth Outcomes Job Market Paper

Abstract. Washington’s Initiative 1183 privatized spirits retail in June 2012, expanding sales through grocery and big-box stores. Nielsen Homescan estimates indicate a 35% increase in projected household spirits purchases. I combine restricted-use natality records with exposure assigned by estimated fertilization month and estimate repeated-cross-section synthetic difference-in-differences models using donor and time weights learned only from pre-policy birth outcomes. The preferred estimates imply a 10.3-gram decline in average birth weight, a 0.274-percentage-point increase in low birth weight, and a 0.357-percentage-point increase in small-for-gestational-age births. Distributional estimates suggest movement toward lower and borderline-low birth-weight categories. These estimates remain imprecise under one-treated-state placebo inference, however, and a prespecified adverse-health index is near zero. Together with mixed evidence on gestation, condition at birth, and selection, the results provide suggestive, rather than definitive, intention-to-treat evidence that expanded spirits access adversely affected lower-tail fetal growth among observed live births.

Working Papers

Did Decriminalization Increase Overdoses? (with Benjamin Hansen and Kyutaro Matsuzawa).
[NBER Working Paper No. 35427](#).

Abstract. This paper asks whether drug decriminalization increased overdose mortality using Oregon’s Measure 110 and Washington’s *Blake* decision as two major policy changes. We use synthetic-control methods to construct matched counterfactuals for each state and examine changes in drug arrests and overdose deaths following decriminalization. Both policies sharply reduced drug arrests and were followed by sustained increases in overdose mortality relative to their synthetic controls. The estimates imply approximately 1,186 excess deaths in Oregon and 1,895 in Washington from 2021 through 2023. We also revisit the role of fentanyl supply and show that commonly used fentanyl-share measures can partly reflect enforcement-driven declines in non-fentanyl drug reports. Alternative measures of fentanyl exposure continue to yield positive overdose effects, suggesting that changes in fentanyl availability alone do not account for the estimated increases in mortality.

Does Substance Use Treatment Still Reduce Mortality?

Abstract. This paper asks whether expanded substance use disorder treatment access continued to reduce overdose mortality as the opioid epidemic shifted toward fentanyl and polysubstance use. I combine county-level treatment-center measures with National Vital Statistics System mortality data from 1999 through 2022, replicate estimates from the early epidemic, and apply methods suited to heterogeneous, non-binary treatment. The protective relationship found in earlier years weakens over time: full-period estimates are near zero or positive, and year-specific estimates suggest gradual erosion rather than a single COVID-era break. The results show that earlier population-level estimates may not generalize to the synthetic-opioid era and highlight the difficulty of measuring treatment access when treatment capacity and the drug supply evolve simultaneously.

The Deterrence Impacts of Fentanyl Supply Laws.

Abstract. This paper studies California Assembly Bill 701, which extended drug-weight sentencing enhancements to fentanyl and increased penalties above one kilogram. State-level synthetic-control estimates using UCR arrest data provide little evidence that the law reduced aggregate drug activity. Incident-level NIBRS estimates, however, show a shift away from quantities above the threshold and toward lower-weight incidents. I find no meaningful effect on overdose mortality. The results suggest that threshold-based sentence enhancements can change how illicit-market activity is organized without reducing overall participation.

Work in Progress

- *Treatment Center Ownership and Market Learning*
- *Did Retail Availability of Naloxone Affect Elasticity?*
- *Public Provision and Crowding Out: The Case of Naloxone*
- *A Regime-Switching Model of the Opioid Epidemic*

Conference Presentations

Poor Decisions: Alcohol Privatization and Birth Outcomes — ASHEcon Annual Conference, June 2026.

Did Decriminalization Increase Overdoses? — WEAI Annual Conference, July 2026; APPAM Fall Research Conference, November 2025; ASHEcon Annual Conference, June 2024.

Does Substance Use Treatment Still Reduce Mortality? — Western Social Science Association Annual Conference, April 2025.

Professional and Public Service

Council Member, Behavioral Health Resource Network Oversight and Accountability Council, Oregon Health Authority 2026–Present

President, Economics GE Guild, University of Oregon AY 2024–2025

Ad hoc referee: *Journal of Health Economics*; *Studies in Non-Linear Dynamics and Econometrics*; *International Review of Law and Economics*; *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications*; *Drug and Alcohol Review*.

Undergraduate Thesis Mentor, University of Oregon 2026
Student: Jaya Baker.

Council Member, Emmaus Fund, Emmaus Lutheran Church, Eugene, Oregon.

Mentor, Women in Economics, University of Oregon.

Guest Lecturer, UO Student Academy to Inspire Learning (SAIL), 2024 and 2026.

Awards and Honors

University of Oregon First-Year Econometrics Award 2023

IIF Certificate of Forecasting 2021

University Honors Program with Distinction 2021

Economics Departmental Distinction 2020

Overton Summer Research Fellowship 2020

Presidential Scholar 2017–2021

Dean's List 2017–2021

Technical Skills

Advanced: R **Intermediate:** Python, Stata, EViews, MySQL, Power BI

Additional Experience and Memberships

Pricing Analyst, AmeriHome Mortgage Company, LLC, Thousand Oaks, California January 2021–May 2022

Memberships: American Economic Association; American Society for Health Economics.